



competing with her." Her family was close to Raje before they fell out when the Jaipur Development Authority seized part of their Rajmahal Palace in 2016. The high command intervened quickly to restore status quo ante. Since then, the unspoken 'battle royale' has become a matter of curiosity. Vidyadhar Nagar is soaking in all the limelight. At her rallies, it's 'Diyas for Diya'. Upon her merest prodding, the audience lights up venues with their mobile phone torches. Will Diwali come to her palace on December 3? ■

OMG!

It's an almighty coalition between spiritual and temporal. Yagnas, chanting purohits, mahants, fakirs, bhajan singers—like always in India, all the beady-eyed shades of the divine can be spotted in the electoral arena. The other day, Telangana CM K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR), his crown a tad shaky, held a three-day 'Raja Shyamala Sahita Subramanyeswara Yagam' at his 40-acre farmhouse at Erravalli. Legend has it that kings performed this yagna before they went to battle. Some 170 priests from all over, under the expert eye of Sarada Peetham head Sri Swami Swaroopananda Saraswati, came together to propitiate goddess Raja Shyamala Devi.



From right clockwise: Sadhvi Anadi Saraswati, KCR, Prakash Mali, Swami Balmukundacharya

Some 800 miles to the north as the crow flies, Swami Balmukundacharya, the angelic-looking mahant of Hathoj dham, has rolled up his saffron sleeves to contest from the Hawa Mahal seat in Rajasthan. Bhajan singer Prakash Mali is serenading Pachpadra with his nasal-inflected invocations, again for the BJP. Matching colours are to be seen in Tijara and Pokhran: Alwar MP and Nath sect mahant Balaknath and the Taratara math's mahant Pratap Puri are doing the honours. Puri had lost in 2018 to the Congress's Shale Mohammad, of the Sindhi Muslim Hurs sect. His father, Ghazi Faqir, was a Sufi leader. The Congress also pulled a surprise, getting the rather prepossessing Sadhvi Anadi Saraswati to defect after the BJP denied her a ticket from Ajmer North. Ramanand peeth seer Somendra's wife Archana Sharma is also consecrating the soil at Malviya Nagar, with the Congress palm presumably in 'abhaya mudra'. ■

Azza Pads Up

Stance, style, flick...everything was intact when he won from UP's Moradabad in 2009 wearing Congress colours. But uncharacteristically for ex-India cricket captain Mohammed Azharuddin, 60, timing and placement deserted him in Rajasthan's Tonk-Sawai Madhopur in 2014. After cooling his heels in the pavilion, he's bracing for another innings, this time to be a MLA, back in native Hyderabad. But the Jubilee Hills constituency is turning out to be a dodgy pitch. The Congress had had bad outings here the last two times. Sitting BRS MLA Maganti Gopinath, in fact, has got a runner. P. Vishnuvardhan Reddy, who won from here on a Congress ticket in 2009, has joined the rival team, exiting the GOP in a rage after 'Ajju bhai' got the ticket. Asaduddin Owaisi's AIMIM is still reading the conditions and may send out a pinch-hitter too. All are playing for the 27 per cent Muslim vote. Azza is also nursing an injury: he was booked recently in a criminal case for allegedly flicking Rs 3.8 crore from the Hyderabad Cricket Association. ■

